move them from their error."[8]

There was one good thing about the Prussians, Nicolaus von Jeroschin adds as an afterthought: they "lived at peace with the Christians who had settled alongside them." This was soon to end.

The Polans, just a little ahead of the Lithuanian tribes in the evolution of their state, saw them as fair game. Konrad of Mazovia offered the Teutonic Knights another opportunity to crusade: they could come into his dukedom and fight against the enemies of Christ who lived around the Vistula. In exchange, he promised them a northern tract of land in his dukedom for their own "in perpetuity . . . and in addition the lands which they might conquer thereafter with the help of God."[9]

For a relatively small payout, Konrad thus got a heavily armed, zealous, and experienced border guard. The Teutonic Knights gained a base of operations and the chance to conquer a kingdom, plus all the benefits of holy war: In 1226, Honorius III declared the fight against Lithuanian-speakers to be a new crusade, complete with full absolution of sin for those who took part.



40.1 The Baltic Crusade

The Teutonic Knights took some time to organize and assemble themselves, but in 1233 the first invasion of Prussia, across the Vistula river, began. It was the beginning of a war that would last for decades. What began as the "Baltic Crusade" turned into an ugly, bloody, protracted struggle in which (as the historian Kenneth Setton puts it), "primitive tribes with no